SALES OPERATIONS

Which Version of the Job Are You Pricing?

How a materials supplier can give a useful early answer and still know when a quote is ready to be relied on.



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The builder wants a hardwood price by four. You have an interior schedule that says engineered oak, a marked-up plan that adds the second-floor corridor, and a text from the designer asking whether the price includes stairs. The buyer's spreadsheet has one cell for flooring. Your estimate will probably end up in that cell, even if you send three pages of notes.

The estimator can produce a number. Before she does, someone has to decide what that number means. Is it for an owner deciding whether to keep hardwood in the budget? Is it a commitment a builder can carry into a bid? Is purchasing expected to order from it as soon as the deposit arrives?

A materials supplier should collect enough information for the decision the quote supports. A budget needs a stated basis and assumptions. A firm quote needs the governing plans, quantities, specifications, scope, and terms. A release to order also needs confirmed selections and the authority to act. Record missing facts and conflicting instructions beside the line items they affect.

Why do a budget and a firm quote need different inputs?

Ask how the recipient will use the price before deciding what must be verified. A range can help a buyer choose between options while details are still open. A firm quote carries a more specific promise about what will be supplied and under which conditions. Ordering commits money against that promise.

At The Home Depot, someone shopping for carpet can compare materials and use a cost guide to get a sense of price. The in-home measure serves a different purpose. It confirms room dimensions and flags conditions such as an uneven subfloor before the retailer issues a final quote with materials, labor, and any extra charges. You can use an early number to decide which carpet is worth considering, then use a measured scope to decide what to buy. A builder needs the same distinction when a flooring number goes from a budget spreadsheet to a bid. The Home Depot's carpet installation process

What the buyer needs	What to capture	What the buyer should see
A budget to compare two materials	Approximate area, material range, intended rooms, major exclusions	Range or conditional price with assumptions near the number.
A firm price to carry into a bid	Applicable plan and revision, quantities and units, agreed selection, inclusions, delivery and validity	A specific scope and terms, plus named items still outside the price.
A release for purchasing	Approved item and finish, final quantities, delivery and acceptance record, authorized release	A record the supplier can order from and reconcile with what was approved.

If the buyer says “quote” and cannot tell you which of these they need, ask what decision the price will go into. That question can save more work than sending a longer intake form.

What should you do when the drawings and schedule disagree?

Show the conflict in terms of what it changes. Record the source and revision, name the person who can resolve it, and say which part of the price can proceed. A schedule and a plan can both be current and still contradict each other.

In the hardwood example, suppose the scope list covers 6,400 square feet and the plan markup adds 700. An assumed 10% allowance on 6,400 gives 7,040 square feet to price. With the additional area, the same allowance gives 7,810. The difference is 770 square feet before anyone counts stair treads. Put that difference where the estimator or builder can see it. If the figures are preliminary, say so beside the number the builder will copy.

Think about pricing roof trusses. The company designing the trusses needs the dimensions and loads it will design for. Simpson Strong-Tie’s published engineering terms make a distinction between the work it agrees to do and who is responsible for verifying information supplied by the customer, subject to the terms’ qualifications. The question for a supplier is practical. If a new drawing changes the span, who can confirm the dimension before anyone prices or orders against it? Simpson Strong-Tie truss services terms

For the hardwood quote, the builder may be able to confirm which rooms to include while the designer is still selecting the finish. Treat those as separate decisions. Issue a useful budget for the agreed area if it fits the buyer’s purpose. Show the finish as an assumption and the stairs as a separate item to confirm. When the job moves to order, check that every open decision has an answer or a documented reason to stay outside the release.

What should go next to a provisional number?

Write the part a buyer can copy without losing the assumption. For example, “Budget based on 6,400 square feet of floor area plus the estimating allowance. Corridor and stairs separate until scope is confirmed.” Then show the corridor as an alternate with its own quantity. If the builder puts only the base number in a comparison sheet, ask whether they can compare it fairly with a supplier who included the corridor. Offer to reconcile the two scopes before the builder carries a firm price.

The same habit protects the handoff to purchasing. A quantity may be safe as an estimating basis and still need verification before material is ordered. Record who owns the site measurement and whether the final number can change. A blanket instruction to “confirm all dimensions” gives the buyer little help if the corridor is the issue and the estimator already knows it.

How do you keep the same intake gap from coming back?

Review a handful of quotes that came back for rework. Find what your team had to ask for, who had it, and when it became available. Then move the question to the point where someone can answer it. Asking earlier helps when the information exists earlier.

A Quote Intake Record for the corridor might read: “700 square feet shown only on the marked-up plan. Builder to confirm inclusion before firm bid. Budget shows both totals. Stairs separate. Finish pending design approval. Purchasing hold until approved selection and area are reconciled.” That record should travel with the quote. When purchasing takes over, it can see what has been decided and what it would be committing the business to.

If many buyers can give a room list but have no measured quantities, make the room list easy to send and explain how a provisional quantity becomes final. If sales forwards new attachments without saying which file governs, fix who consolidates revisions. A longer form adds work without settling that problem.

Three checks before the quote goes out.

- Write down the decision the price supports.
- Put the assumption or conflicting quantity beside the affected price.
- Give every open item an owner and an event that must happen before purchasing relies on it.

At four, the builder can still have a number for his spreadsheet. The estimator can say exactly what it covers. Both will have something to work from when the corridor comes up again.

Frequently asked questions

Can a supplier quote before the final drawings are issued?

It can provide a budget or a conditional price if the available information supports one. Explain which drawings it relies on, what may change and when the figure can become a firm quote.

Should the online form require all the information needed to order?

Use only the fields needed to take the next useful step. Ask for more when the buyer is ready for a specific quote or release. Make it clear which information is required at each stage.

How should the supplier handle a late revision?

Identify the affected line items, confirm the applicable revision with the authorized person, and issue a traceable update. Ask the buyer to confirm which version they're carrying if the change affects their decision.

The flooring scenario and quantities are illustrative. The Home Depot and Simpson Strong-Tie references are drawn from public documentation.